

Cause & Effect Analysis for High Average Handle Time

Problem Statement

Average Handle Time (AHT) in the support center has increased to about 9 minutes per call. This analysis aims to list and organize potential causes before we test them with data. Fishbone (Ishikawa) diagrams and Why-Why questions are common root-cause tools in the Analyze phase. [web:595][web:608]

Fishbone Categories and Potential Causes

People

- New agents are not fully confident on complex topics.
- Senior agents get many escalations and are overloaded.
- Different agents use different call flows.

Process

- Call flow is not documented in one simple place.
- Many calls are transferred between “general” and “billing” queues.
- Wrap-up notes are long and sometimes duplicated in two systems.

Technology

- Knowledge base search is slow and results are not well ranked.
- Agents switch between three systems to see full customer history.
- Occasional “system not responding” errors cause re-entry of data.

Policy / Measurement

- Agents are told “never leave a question unanswered” but have no time limits.
- Quality reviews focus on call friendliness more than call efficiency.
- No clear rule on when to transfer versus when to own a case.

Why-Why Mini-Chains

Example 1: Long “research” time

1. Why are research steps long? → Agents take time to find the right article.
2. Why is it hard to find the right article? → Search results show many outdated entries.
3. Why are outdated entries still shown? → There is no regular review or archive process.

Example 2: Many transfers

1. Why are there many transfers? → Agents are unsure if they are allowed to resolve billing issues.
2. Why are they unsure? → Policy is vague and training examples are limited.
3. Why is policy vague? → The billing process changed, but training material was not updated.

Data Collected to Check Causes

To avoid guessing, the team collected a small but focused data set of 50 calls:

- Call type (general question, billing, refund, technical).
- AHT for each call.
- Whether the call was transferred (yes/no).
- Number of times the agent opened the knowledge base.

How the Data Was Interpreted

Simple averages showed that:

- Calls with at least one transfer were on average 4 minutes longer.
- Billing and refund calls had the highest average AHT.
- Calls where the agent opened the knowledge base more than 3 times were almost always in the “long call” group.

These patterns support the earlier Why-Why ideas: unclear ownership of billing questions and slow or hard-to-use

knowledge search are strong candidates for real root causes.